

LEARNER FRIENDLY ENVIRONMENT



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9.1 INTRODUCTION

In the previous chapter, we saw that the sooner we identify children with special needs (disabilities) and learning disabilities, the more we can accelerate their development by providing them with the necessary support. Children with special needs (especially those with learning disabilities) require special attention to provide them education according to their abilities. We understood the definition of an inclusive environment and its importance, which basically entails understanding that every child has the full right to receive education,

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irrespective of their level of ability, as per the law of this country. Along with the early identification of such children and strategies for their identification, we also understood the concept and use of Individualised Education Plan (IEP), which helps children with disabilities to effectively progress to their full potential. The aim of education is to blossom the inherent powers of the child, refine and internalize them, and develop moral character to complete social adjustment. Keeping this aim in mind, in this chapter we will try to understand the needs of physical, emotional and social development (holistic development) of children. Giving importance to the differences of students, implementing positive, inclusive, and motivating teaching strategies in the class is no less than a challenge for the teacher. By reducing these challenges as much as possible, teaching methods have been discussed to meet the diverse needs of all children in an inclusive learning environment. Along with this, the main objective of this chapter is to explore the methods of creating a learner-friendly environment by identifying the obstacles related to children's learning and designing appropriate support strategies.

**9.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES**

After completion of this chapter, the learner:

- explains, the holistic developmental needs of children, particularly including physical, emotional, social, and learning aspects;
- applies positive, inclusive, and motivating teaching strategies in the classroom;
- adapts teaching methods to meet the diverse needs of all children, creating inclusive learning environments;
- identifies learning barriers faced by children with special needs and design appropriate support strategies.

9.3 LEARNER-FRIENDLY ENVIRONMENT

It is an atmosphere where learners feel comfortable, encouraged, and inspired to learn, explore, and continue their journey of lifelong learning. Teachers must be aware of children's psychological needs, especially those related to their cognitive and developmental phases in order to establish such an atmosphere. Children's skill development, interactions with their surroundings, and

information processing are all impacted by these demands.

An educational setting that considers needs, interests, and skills of every child, especially those with special needs (Divyang) and learning disabilities, seeks to give each child a sense of security, inspiration, and support. Its prominent characteristics are:

Inclusivity: All children are welcomed regardless of their emotional, mental, or physical health. The concept of inclusion involves establishing an atmosphere in which every person irrespective of their identity, background, or abilities experiences equal access to resources and opportunities and feels appreciated and respected. This entails active embrace of diversity, dismantling of obstacles, and cultivation of a sense of belonging for everyone.

Safety and support: Teachers, peers and school personnel foster a welcoming and encouraging atmosphere that allows children to study without fear.

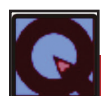
Utilization of resources: Proper instructional materials, technology, and special education help are offered, and children's accomplishments are valued.

Use of IEP: Individualised Education Plan is prepared for every child. An Individual Education Plan (IEP) is used to establish specific objectives and instructional methods for every kid.

Encouragement and resources: Proper instructional materials, technology, and special instructors are used to help children and acknowledge their accomplishments. Children can develop academically, socially, and emotionally in this setting, which enables them to realise their greatest potential.

Differentiated teaching : Differentiated teaching refers to instructional strategies like visual, auditory, or activity-based learning that are tailored to each child's unique needs.

Early intervention: The techniques used in this approach are used to identify and assist learning impairments (slow learners) in a timely manner.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 9.1

1. What is a key feature of a learner-friendly environment?
 - a) Only focusing on academic performance.

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- b) Encouraging competition among students.
- c) Adapting teaching methods to a child's unique needs.
- d) Using a single teaching method for all students.

2. Which of the following is an example of an IEP?

- a) A plan created for all students in a classroom.
- b) A plan to improve a school's infrastructure.
- c) A plan to help a specific student with a learning difficulty by setting tailored goals.
- d) A plan that focuses on a student's weaknesses.

Answer: 1-c; 2-c

9.4 INCLUSIVE EDUCATION

Inclusive education is an educational approach that provides all children regardless of their learning styles, abilities, disabilities, etc, especially children with special needs (Divyang). It ensures that children with disabilities or other special needs join the general classroom and receive education tailored to their needs. Its main features are:

Equal opportunity: All children have the right to equal education irrespective of their abilities or disabilities.

Early intervention: Early identification of learning disabilities and implementation of appropriate intervention strategies.

Importance of IEP: Children's individual education plans (IEPs) set their goals and modifications.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 9.2

1. What is the main goal of inclusive education?

- a) To separate children based on their abilities.
- b) To ensure all children, including those with special needs, can learn in the general classroom.

- c) To focus only on children with special needs.
 - d) To provide education only for high-achieving students.
2. What is a key feature of inclusive education?
- a) Delaying intervention for learning disabilities.
 - b) Providing education only for children without disabilities.
 - c) Giving all children equal opportunity to learn.
 - d) Ignoring the use of IEPs.

Answer: 1-b; 2-c

9.5 DIFFERENCE BETWEEN LEARNER-FRIENDLY ENVIRONMENT AND INCLUSIVE EDUCATION

Both inclusive education and learner-friendly environments aim to create a supportive learning environment, but they differ in a few ways.

Table 9.1: Difference between Learner-Friendly Environment and Inclusive Education

Learner-Friendly Environment	Inclusive Education
It's known as an environment.	Inclusive education means education that is inclusive.
Learner-friendly education seeks to promote learning.	It's known as a strategy.
Learner-friendly environment is a component of classroom instruction.	Inclusive education is a method of teaching.
The goal of a learner-friendly environment is to provide students a welcoming, secure, and engaging space where they can study without fear.	A complete strategy known as inclusive education, on the other hand, guarantees that all children may learn in the same classroom regardless of their talents or limitations. In other words, inclusive education seeks to guarantee social equality and education for all

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It entails using instructional strategies, equipment, and materials that are appropriate for the needs and learning preferences of the children.	It gives every student an equal chance to study and succeed.
Its main goal is to make learning better for every learner.	The goal is to establish a setting in which each child feels valued and unique.
It motivates educators to establish a welcoming and engaging atmosphere for all children.	Students who require extra help and modifications are also included.
It covers instructional strategies, classroom dynamics, and instructor conduct in a way that allows pupils to learn without anxiety or pressure.	Inclusive education is an educational strategy that guarantees all students, irrespective of their physical, mental, social, or cultural backgrounds, can learn alongside one another in the same classroom (mainstream education).
Open communication and cooperation between students and teachers. It includes interactive teaching strategies and applies to all students in general. This makes learning enjoyable, such as games, group debates, or project-based learning.	It focuses on students who may be socially, physically, or cognitively challenged.

To put it briefly, while inclusive education aims to include all students in the classroom, regardless of their ability or disability, learner-friendly environment concentrates on enhancing the classroom learning environment.

While inclusive education focuses on giving all students equal opportunity, learner-friendly environment works to improve instructional strategies, resources, and tools.

In conclusion, inclusive education can include a learner-friendly environment, but its purview is wider because it places a particular emphasis on equality and diversity.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 9.3**

1. Which of the following best describes the main difference between a learner-friendly environment and inclusive education?
 - a) A learner-friendly environment is a broad strategy, while inclusive education is a component of classroom instruction.
 - b) A learner-friendly environment focuses on classroom experience, while inclusive education is a broader strategy for social equality.
 - c) A learner-friendly environment applies only to children with special needs.
 - d) Inclusive education focuses only on improving instructional strategies.
2. Which concept emphasizes providing equal opportunities for all students, regardless of their abilities?
 - a) Learner-friendly environment.
 - b) Differentiated teaching.
 - c) Holistic development.
 - d) Inclusive education.

Answer: 1-b; 2-d

9.6 HOLISTIC DEVELOPMENT

The term holistic development encompasses child's all-around growth in various aspects—physical, cognitive, emotional, and social—to guarantee that they achieve their complete potential as an integrated individual. Holistic development acknowledges the interconnection of all aspects of a child's life, in contrast to conventional methods that may concentrate solely on physical or academic growth. For instance, adequate nutrition (physical) aids cognitive brain function, and a supportive environment (emotional) promotes self-esteem and social skills. The goal of this approach is to develop individuals who are balanced, resilient, and adaptable, enabling them to thrive in diverse contexts. Holistic development is fundamentally based on the integrated addressing of a child's needs. Physical needs like nutrition, sleep, and exercise offer the energy

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and health required for learning and exploration. While social interactions develop skills in communication and cooperation, emotional support fosters confidence and empathy. Cognitive development boosts problem-solving abilities and critical thinking, while spiritual development fosters a sense of purpose and values. Holistic development nurtures all of these aspects, equipping children not just for academic achievement but also for the challenges of life while fostering creativity, well-being, and a sense of community. This framework is crucial during early childhood because the initial years influence long-term health, behaviour, and learning outcomes.

9.6.1 Physical Needs

Focusing on physical needs, these are foundational for children to thrive in all areas of development with physical needs serving as the basis. Essential physical needs include:

1. **Nutrition:** Crucial for development, cognitive advancement, and immune response. Children require a balanced diet, proper hydration, and age-appropriate consideration of dietary restrictions.
2. **Sleep:** Facilitates development, mental processes, and emotional well-being. The recommended hours differ by age (e.g., 14-17 for newborns, 8-10 for teenagers), involving consistent routines and limited screen exposure prior to sleep.
3. **Physical activity:** Enhances motor skills, physical strength, and psychological well-being. Daily activity requirements vary from tummy time for babies to 60 minutes of exercise for school-age children.
4. **Health and safety:** To avert and deal with health issues, it is essential to have regular medical examinations, vaccinations, and a secure environment.

9.6.2 Emotional Needs

Emotional needs play a crucial role in nurturing a child's all-around development, self-worth, resilience, and social connections. Essential emotional needs include:

1. **Secure attachment:** Trust is developed through caring relationships and love.
2. **Emotional validation:** Secure environments for expression and processing

of emotions.

3. **Belonging:** Being part of family, cultural, or friendship circles bolsters identity.
4. **Autonomy:** Confidence is fostered through choices that are suitable for the child's age and encouragement.
5. **Emotional security:** The establishment of stable routines and safeguarding from danger facilitates regulation.
6. **Considerations:** Needs differ based on age, temperament, and cultural/socioeconomic factors. Trust should be nurtured, expression encouraged, healthy emotions exemplified, and well-being monitored by caregivers.

9.6.3 Social Needs

Social needs play a significant role in a child's holistic development. Essential social needs comprise:

1. **Positive relationships:** Supportive connections with family members, peers, and role models foster trust and empathy across all age groups.
2. **Social exchanges and games:** Activities suitable for the age (like cooperative play and team sports) foster communication and problem-solving skills.
3. **Sense of community:** Taking part in events related to culture, family, or the community fosters inclusiveness and strengthens identity.
4. **Communication skills:** Offers chances to hone verbal and nonverbal skills as well as emotional intelligence, with social guidance on appropriate behaviours.
5. **Secure and inclusive environments:** Safeguarding against bullying and fostering inclusivity bolster assured social involvement.
6. **Considerations:** Needs differ based on age, personality, and socioeconomic/cultural factors.

It is important for caregivers to stimulate interaction, provide instruction in social skills, make certain that safe spaces are available, keep track of social health, and promote diversity.

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9.6.4 Learning Needs

From the perspective of holistic development, learning aspects – commonly referred to as cognitive or intellectual needs – are crucial for a child’s capacity to think, reason, solve problems, and acquire knowledge. These contribute to cognitive development, curiosity, and lifelong learning. Presented below is a concise overview of the essential learning needs that will contribute to children’s all-around development. Cognitive needs play a crucial role in a child’s holistic development, fostering thinking, problem-solving abilities, and lifelong learning. Essential learning needs comprise:

1. **Cognitive stimulation:** Challenges suitable for the age group (e.g., puzzles, exploration) foster curiosity and critical thinking.
2. **Access to education:** Quality schooling, resources (such as books and technology), and nurturing environments foster development of basic skills.
3. **Language growth:** Verbal exchanges that are abundant and activities aimed at enhancing vocabulary bolster both academics and communication.
4. **Critical thinking:** Opportunities for problem-solving and decision-making (such as play and real-life tasks) foster independence. Creativity and imagination: Innovative activities (such as art or role-play) promote cognitive flexibility and innovation.

Needs differ based on age, ability, and socioeconomic/cultural factors. Caregivers ought to stimulate curiosity, back education, advance language, cultivate problem-solving, and inspire creativity.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 9.4**

1. Which of the following is NOT a component of holistic development of a child?
 - a) Physical needs.
 - b) Emotional needs.
 - c) Financial needs.
 - d) Social needs.

2. Holistic development is based on the idea that a child's different developmental aspects are:
- Completely separate from one another.
 - Primarily focused on academic success.
 - Interconnected and interdependent.
 - Only relevant during early childhood.

Answer: 1-c; 2-c

9.7 TEACHING STRATEGIES FOR CREATING A LEARNER - FRIENDLY ENVIRONMENT

1. Be an effective listener

A teacher should be an effective listener to help solve problems of children rather than suggesting solutions or offering sympathy, or making derogatory remarks. We know that if someone listens to us carefully, we get mental peace. Similarly, a child also wants someone to listen to him/her, especially when his/her teacher listens to him/her; it is a matter of pride for him/her.

2. Do not label or criticize

Labelling a child or criticizing a child will only close up the possibility of improvement in the child. A teacher rather needs to make grounds for useful discussion for improving child's performance.

3. Handle truancy tactfully

Teaching in accordance with the frequent absenteeism is a widespread issue in schools, but teachers are highly concerned about it since it will impact student development. To help children get past a certain obstacle, a teacher must employ subtlety and strategic thinking. If child returns after long absence, express gratitude instead of reprimanding him/her. Recognize the challenges or circumstances and avoid causing the child additional stress.

4. Identifying children

Teachers should be alert to signs such as poor attention span, negative self-image, difficulty with math, and limited expression in the classroom. Children will be better able to integrate and work toward specific goals if the problem is identified and a plan of action is developed.

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Inclusive Classrooms**Notes****5. Tackle poor self-esteem problem**

Some of the children in class don't think well of themselves and develop low self-esteem. Educators should recognize students and consider measures to support them. It's difficult to set activities that are appropriate in level and pertinent. But a teacher must accomplish this. Teachers can assist students in completing written assignments by planning ahead, outlining the assignment's objective, and emphasising the importance of their work.

6. Use V.A.K.T approach

Make use of multisensory teaching techniques. VAKT (Visual Auditory Kinaesthetic and Tactile) approaches were first presented by Grace Fernald. But more recently, proprioception and vestibular senses have also been employed. This method assists children with a variety of learning challenges in understanding concepts in the most effective way for them. It indicates that the child's strengths and shortcomings are addressed by this approach. Teaching a weakness through strength promotes confidence and a sense of accomplishment, which improves learning. A multisensory approach should be used to plan lessons.

7. Use all senses simultaneously

Following the identification of strengths and shortcomings, a teacher should develop a number of instructional strategies that could improve students' reading, writing, and math skills. Using ears, eyes, voice, fingers, and muscles all at once is known as a multisensory approach. In most cases, this comes naturally, but children who struggle with learning should be taught how to apply these skills in tandem. Utilize a deck of cards with words that contain letters printed on the back and letter patterns printed on the front to improve visual and aural memory. Employ the kinaesthetic sense more frequently. Use the child's kinaesthetic sense to help them recall what they have learned through body language and movement on learning.

8. Incorporate thinking skills

Include "thinking skills lessons" in the curriculum to promote the development of students' observational abilities. Engage in activities to foster these skills. For instance, place a set of everyday objects on a table, allow students to observe them briefly, then cover the objects and ask the

students to recall and describe as many details as possible.

9. Apply “Task Analysis” appropriately.

Task Analysis, involves breaking down the work into sequential parts. In theory, task analysis is simple, but it is challenging in practice. Sometimes the work is not given in the right order, which makes it difficult for the children to learn. When teaching alphabet, for instance, teach one alphabet at a time followed by sequential phases of matching, identifying, and naming. The teacher should adhere to the steps even when teaching matching identification. For instance, identification must be taught in one-, two-, and finally multiple-choice formats after the child has learned matching, and then generalization must follow. After naming, matching is utilized for identification. For learning to be effective, the right teaching order is crucial.

10. Make teaching math fun

Make mathematics teaching fun using games, activities and reinforce concepts. Teachers should relate mathematics to everyday experience. Do not assume that mental arithmetic is too difficult for slow learners. Just be sure to start from an appropriate level.

11. Improve unacceptable behaviour

Each child is different from other. A teacher should be knowledgeable about methods of management and the way in which problematic behaviour is learned and managed.

12. Use peer tutoring

By pairing the child with a more accomplished performer to assist him/her in finishing the assignment helps to motivate and enhance the child's performance. Care should be taken while choosing a peer to assist the child. He/She should be aware of their needs. Until the tutor-tutee relationship is satisfactory, train the tutor and provide supervision. Give them both a reward for doing the assignment successfully.

13. Be an effective support teacher

In inclusive schools, a teacher will have to work in a range of classrooms. They should collaborate with the regular teachers. Provide useful assistance to the mainstream coworker.

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Inclusive Classrooms**Notes****14. Use cooperative learning**

Cooperative learning is an additional strategy to engage every student in the classroom. The group may be divided into smaller groups, each group comprising with varying skill levels. They should work together to complete the assigned task. Teaching English, Math, and other topics in a group setting will help students with special needs develop their social skills in addition to their academic performance.

15. Proper Use of Teaching and Learning Materials (TLMs)

For TLMs to truly support learning, they should be aligned with the teaching strategy being followed. When teaching children with learning difficulties, TLMs should be introduced step by step—starting with simple, clear materials and gradually moving to more complex ones. Overloading the child with too many materials at once may confuse them and reduce the effectiveness of the lesson.

16. Stay fit

To be effective at teaching profession, teachers need to take care of themselves. A teacher should learn to enjoy even the tiniest accomplishment. Take help of a colleague when face a specific problem. A teacher should take out time for stress relieving activities like swimming, dancing, yoga and meditation.

A teacher should be in good physical and mental condition. She/He should adapt the approach to the child's preferred method of learning. A modern teacher's methodical, well-thought-out application of activities will significantly impact a child's learning.

9.7.1 Some other Strategies for Creating a Learner-Friendly Environment**1. Team Teaching**

Teachers of various subjects must collaborate on a single teaching topic to enable students to demonstrate their learning abilities more appropriately. Students will have the chance to comprehend the same idea from a variety of perspectives. This will facilitate an environment that is conducive to learning. Hence, at times a teacher should teach as a team.

2. Peer Tutoring

In peer tutoring, a student serves as both the tutor and the tutee, giving and receiving education one-on-one. Peer tutoring provides remedial or supporting instruction to match each student's unique requirements. The following are the steps involved in peer tutoring:

- Evaluate each student's performance in the class.
- Create a profile of the tutee's performance across all developmental domains.
- Determine the students' areas of strength in order to choose peer tutors.
- Assign the tutee to the instructor. The tutor should be knowledgeable about the subject and capable of imparting knowledge that the tutee needs to learn.
- Create modified teaching resources ahead of time for the tutee and peer tutor to utilize. For instance, a communication board might need to be set up for a child who struggles with communication.
- Arrange for tutors to receive a brief training on how to properly teach children with special needs. The teacher and peer tutor must evaluate and address the specific needs in Children with special needs
- Explain to the peer tutor the student's current profile and the expectations for the student's performance within a specific time frame. For CWSN with little cerebral capacity, a lot of practice might be necessary.
- Provide the tutee and the peer tutor with detailed instructions.
- Provide a comfortable workspace for tutoring.
- Create a workable plan while taking into account how convenient both are.
- Appreciate the tutee on his progress and the tutor on a job well done.
- Foster positive ties between them by supporting each other's performance. Track the tutoring progress.
- If necessary, switch tutors for various classes, exams, or revision sessions.
- Above all, get the tutee's and tutor's parents' consent for this activity. They must be persuaded that it benefits both of them. It is necessary to inform

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parents that both the tutor and the tutee learn best together.

3. Cooperative Learning

Cooperative learning is a strategy in which groups employ to accomplish a shared objective with assistance and cooperation from one another.

4. Language Learning

The language learning approach combines the improvement of speaking, writing, and listening abilities with the growth of reading capabilities. The content for the lesson would come from the child's thoughts and conversations.

Many children with locomotor disabilities, such as those with muscular dystrophy, polio, vision impairment, and certain forms of spina bifida, may speak like any other student in the class.

Children with conditions such as cerebral palsy, intellectual disabilities, hearing impairment, or certain forms of spina bifida may think, speak, or communicate differently. In such cases, the teacher should make extra efforts to connect learning with the child's own experiences, or provide opportunities of experiential learning.

5. Multi-Sensory Approach

The multisensory method is predicated on the idea that presenting knowledge in multiple ways can facilitate learning. In addition to visual and aural modalities, kinaesthetic and tactile stimuli should be employed.

6. Programmed Breakthrough to Literacy

The foundation of a long-term retention plan should be the child's involvement in teaching learning process. Some children with special needs, such as those with hearing impairment, mental retardation, cerebral palsy, or spinal bifida, may find it difficult to read. One such technique to help them is Programmed learning. The plan entails taking the following actions:

The children recounts their experiences.

- The cards with spoken words and letters then are ready. While the children narrates, the teacher organizes the cards. Then the teacher reads it aloud, the student repeats it until he/she can read it on his/her own.

Work analyses: Divide the work that needs to be learned into manageable

and teachable parts. Each component is transferred to the child after being sequenced. Only after the child has mastered the first few components, the following one taught.

7. Modifying Materials and Activities

There are numerous instructional strategies that can be used when teaching social studies. Teachers can use learning materials, talks, and demonstrations in the classroom. Other interesting methods include role-playing, dramatic improvisation, and simulation exercises. Some strategies that educators can use to improve student performance are listed here:

- Textual material: Create vocabulary activities and study/reading aids. Utilize a language experience method, create graphic organizers, edit materials, preview reading selections, and assign additional tasks to pupils once they finish reading them.
- Independent study: Teach self-study, library and research skills.
- Utilize organisers, practice taking notes, adhere to pre-made outlines, and frame outlines.
- Inquiry approaches: Place emphasis on cooperative learning and learner centric instruction. Field visits to historical places, museums, and local areas can be interesting activities that take place outside the classroom. One main and abundant source of knowledge is the local neighbourhood.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 9.5

1. What does the VAKT approach to teaching stand for?
 - a) Visual, Auditory, Knowledge, and Technology.
 - b) Verbal, Analytical, Kinesthetic, and Tactile.
 - c) Visual, Auditory, Kinesthetic, and Tactile.
 - d) Visual, Assessment, Knowledge, and Teaching.
2. Why is it important to use task analysis in teaching?
 - a) It makes lessons more challenging for students.
 - b) It allows a teacher to skip steps in the learning process.

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- c) It breaks down work into manageable, sequential parts for effective learning.
- d) It is only useful for teaching mathematics.

Answer: 1-c; 2-c

9.8 TEACHING METHODS

Teachers use certain techniques to introduce or explain knowledge, skills and values to students with different abilities present in the class. These techniques help in making teaching interesting and goal-oriented. These techniques are known as teaching methods. They are selected on the basis of the needs of the students, the nature of the subject and the objectives of teaching. Through these methods, teachers can make their teaching effective, interesting and diverse. Various methods of teaching have been described by psychologists, such as - lecture method, discussion method, project method, etc. Here, we will understand some important points to help teachers deal with some of the obstacles in the teaching process.

9.8.1 Understanding the Needs

To create a learner friendly environment, it is essential to identify diverse needs of the students and plan accordingly. With parental assistance, gaining insight into the requirements of CWSN can yield a significant amount of useful data regarding the child's needs.

The needs of CWSN can be classified into two categories: learning/academic (both curricular and co-curricular) needs, and supportive needs (medical or assistive aids and devices). A child with sensory loss might not hear or communicate in a typical manner. S/he might not be able to learn or take part in class like other children without impairment. A child with an intellectual or learning disability might struggle to learn at the same pace as their peers or may not acquire certain skills as expected of other children in the same class. The teacher should first determine the learning needs in connection with the curriculum in order to create effective lesson plans and classroom practices. Secondly, with regard to supportive measures and medical rehabilitation/therapy, the child may need specialized equipment and training. Parents or resource support teachers from the community can help in arranging and providing these supportive services as per the child's needs.

9.8.2 Educational Planning

To begin planning, a direct approach is to evaluate the child's strengths and weaknesses. This allows for the creation of plans based on strengths instead of weaknesses.

A Child who is slow in subjects may have an interest in or potential for activities such as sports and cultural events. Recognizing learning gaps caused by impairments or other issues is crucial. Education plans should be developed to address these gaps from an educational standpoint, focusing on curriculum objectives rather than medical diagnoses.

Planning should focus on curriculum and learning needs rather than solely on disability; the foundation should be on understanding of learning gaps within the context of the curriculum, not just the textbook. Instead of focusing solely on textbooks, the teacher should grasp the objectives/competencies relevant to the subject for the specific class the child is in, as these can help to create a baseline and pinpoint gaps. The teacher can devise plans and approaches using his/her creativity that ultimately fulfil the learning outcome.

9.8.3 Peer Support

Assistance from peer groups helps the child build confidence, a crucial aspect of fostering a learner-friendly environment. It has been noted that, at many times, CWSN rely on assistance from their peers to deal with their learning challenges. Thus, implementing peer support measures enhances the effectiveness of a learner-friendly environment.

9.8.4 Pinpoint Existing Resources in School and Community

Listing all supports and services available for children is essential. These services can be found with government entities, NGOs, philanthropic organizations, health centres, various schemes, and more. Another significant aspect in the establishment of a learner-friendly environment is concerned with the availability and use of facilities, furniture, and materials. We need to understand what adjustments could be made to the classroom or school environment (including buildings, etc.) to facilitate the child's attendance and learning?

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**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 9.6**

1. What is the purpose of teaching methods?
 - a) To make all students learn at the same pace.
 - b) To make teaching interesting and goal-oriented.
 - c) To only focus on students with disabilities.
 - d) To evaluate a student's medical needs.
2. Educational planning should focus on a child's:
 - a) Medical diagnosis.
 - b) Weaknesses.
 - c) Strengths and learning gaps within the curriculum.
 - d) Social status.

Answer: a-b; 2-c

9.9 CHALLENGES TO LEARNER-FRIENDLY ENVIRONMENT FACED BY CHILDREN WITH SPECIAL NEEDS AND DESIGNING APPROPRIATE SUPPORT STRATEGIES

Although there are organized and large-scale initiatives to 'mainstream' or include CWSN in regular classrooms, numerous challenges persist regarding attitudes and infrastructure. Below are several reasons that illustrate why the idea of including CWSN still has much progress to make:

9.9.1 Reliable tools

Teachers have access to very few trustworthy tools for evaluating how well CWSN understand the material, so as to confirm that they are progressing at the same rate as their classmates. Special educators usually fulfil this requirement through creative teaching and remedial work activities, that a mainstream teacher might not have the time to engage in.

Students with special needs, often referred to as CWSN, frequently find it challenging to keep up with the lessons being taught in class. They often

require their lessons to be customized to fit their abilities. Both require greater investment of time and attention from their teachers.

9.9.2 Communication

To be socially accepted, it is essential to communicate. In an inclusive environment, most CWSN struggle with appropriate communication. This frequently leads to behaviours that do not align with what their peers. The result is unusual behaviour and a decline in self-esteem, both stemming from frustration and anxiety.

9.9.3 Some Obstacles to Create Inclusive Education

To create a inclusive classroom in which all students thrive, learn, and feel a sense of belonging, it is necessary to tackle various challenges. Below are some of the most frequent obstacles that impede student learning –

1. Pedagogical Barriers to Inclusive Education –

Teaching approaches that may not accommodate diverse learning styles create barriers. Picture a scenario where a teacher uses only lectures for a class of students whose optimal learning comes from hands-on activities or visual work. Some students may be left behind due to this approach. Inclusive pedagogy encompasses employing diverse teaching strategies and assessment methods to guarantee that every student has the opportunity to learn.

2. Structural Barriers to Inclusive Education -

These are physical constraints within the learning environment. Aa school building that lacks ramps and elevators, rendering it inaccessible for students with mobility impairments. Structural barriers may also encompass the absence of suitable furniture or specialized tools necessary for assisting students with diverse needs.

3. Attitudinal Obstacles to Inclusive Education -

They originate from negative stereotypes or unconscious bias. When a teacher thinks that students with disabilities are incapable of meeting high academic standards, they are establishing an attitudinal barrier. In the same way, classmates who mock those with different learning styles also show attitudinal obstacle. Inclusive classrooms necessitate a change in mentality, promoting acceptance and celebration of diversity.

Inclusive Classrooms



Notes

Inclusive Classrooms**Notes****4. Instructional Barriers to Inclusive Education –**

These barriers pertain to how content is delivered in the classroom. Is the curriculum overly inflexible, providing minimal chances for differentiation according to individual needs? Do we have limited resources in various formats, such as audiobooks for readers who struggle? Participation can be hindered by instructional materials that are not tailored to the needs of diverse learners. As an example, an online course with solely text-based resources. Content may be inaccessible for students with visual impairments who depend on screen readers.

5. Physical Barriers to Inclusive Education –

These include any restrictions that impede a student's ability to physically access or engage in the classroom. This might involve a shortage of accessible restrooms, narrow doors, or classrooms with inadequate lighting that puts stress on students' eyesight. It is essential for educators to create a physical environment that is inviting and accessible to all learners. Due to the absence of keyboard shortcuts and screen reader compatibility, a student with vision impairments may struggle to navigate the online interface.

6. Social Barriers to Inclusive Education-

These barriers are rooted in larger social problems that affect education. Students can face difficulties due to poverty, limited access to healthcare, and language barriers. Social issues such as poverty or limited access to technology can result in an unequal playing field for online learning. As an example, a student who comes from a family with low income lacks a dependable device for attending online classes. While schools cannot single-handedly solve these problems, they can acknowledge the existence of these societal obstacles and strive to close the gap by offering more support and resources.

7. “Digital Divide” – Obstacles to Inclusive Online Learning –

Although online learning has facilitated ongoing education, it has also caused existing disparities. Not every student has access to computers and a dependable internet connection. Imagine, a child attend, an online class and when the teacher discusses the essential ideas, the Internet drops! Online education does not provide equal conditions for all. Due to unequal access to technology, it resembles a “digital cliff” where some learners may encounter more challenges than others.

9.9.4 Suggestions/Strategies to Address the Need of CWSN**Inclusive Classrooms****1. Eliminate Lecture Monologue:**

Keep in mind that one size doesn't fit all. Not everyone finds that listening to a teacher for an hour is the best way to learn specially for younger learners. Employ diverse teaching styles. Add interactive tasks that encourage students to move and engage in critical thinking. Consider science experiments, discussions about historical events, or teamwork-based art initiatives. Promote group discussions that allow students to learn from and instruct one another.

*Notes***2. Ensure Learning Materials are Accessible :**

- Offer resources in different formats to accommodate various learning styles and address challenges.
- Provide audiobooks for students who find reading difficult or who favour auditory learning.
- Produce captioned videos for students with hearing impairments.
- Provide dyslexia-friendly fonts and downloadable PDFs that include text-to-speech features for students with dyslexia.
- Investigate screen readers and other assistive technologies to guarantee that all individuals can access the information they require.
- Online educators can collaborate with experts to determine and apply suitable learning resources for students with visual impairments, including tactile diagrams or braille versions of essential texts.

3. Shift Mindsets and Promote Acceptance- Challenge Stereotypes and Build a Culture of Respect:

Unconscious bias can hinder inclusion. Hold workshops and discussions to explore unconscious bias and its impact on learning environment. Create a classroom culture that celebrates diversity and fosters empathy. Encourage students to learn about different cultures, backgrounds, and abilities through literature, guest speakers, and classroom projects

4. Reduce Physical Barriers :

This encompasses more than just ramps and wide doorways. Consider

Inclusive Classrooms**Notes**

providing accessible furniture with adjustable heights for students who use wheelchairs or have trouble reaching desks. It is crucial to have unobstructed pathways and grab bars in bathrooms.

5. Overcome the Digital Divide –Link Learners in the Online Sphere:

Although devices and internet hotspots can provide a useful solution, it's important to think about the ongoing expenses and possible limitations. Explore collaborations with community centers or local libraries that provide free internet access and computer use.

6. Team up for Achievement

It is vital to communicate openly. Teachers, parents, and specialists can share insights and develop a comprehensive understanding of each student's needs through regular meetings or online forums. Parents can offer valuable insights into their child's learning style and any specific accommodations required. Professionals like occupational therapists or speech-language pathologists can provide guidance and support strategies.

7. Differences should be celebrated and a sense of belonging cultivated

Students are important. Cultural festivities and activities should be incorporated into the curriculum for both online and in-person classrooms.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 9.7**

1. What is a recommended strategy to overcome the digital divide?
 - a) Relying on text-only resources.
 - b) Holding workshops on unconscious bias.
 - c) Collaborating with community centers to provide free internet access.
 - d) Using only a lecture-based teaching style.

Answer: 1-c

In this chapter, we discussed the concept of a learner-friendly environment, which includes teaching strategies and methods, identifying learning barriers faced by children with special needs, and designing appropriate support strategies to address these challenges. We discussed about positive, inclusive, and motivating strategies for the classroom and teaching strategies. We must

incorporate the diverse needs of all children in an inclusive learning environment when it comes to teaching methods.



9.11 END EXERCISES

1. Describe in your own words a classroom environment that makes it learner-friendly.
2. Which teaching methods accommodate the varied needs of every child?
3. What are your thoughts on learning barriers?
4. What do the acronyms C.W.S.N. and C.W.D. stand for?

9.12 REFERENCES

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